

LOGICAL PROGRESSION

BUILDING TRAINING PROGRAMS FOR YEAR-ROUND CLIMBING PERFORMANCE

SECOND EDITION

STEVE BECHTEL



THIS BOOK IS DEDICATED TO MY DAD, TOM BECHTEL.

HE WAS THE BEST PERSON I HAVE EVER KNOWN.

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PREFACE TO THE SECOND EDITION

I wrote Logical Progression over the winter of 2014/2015, and then grudgingly edited and tested it over the next year. We sent it out to fifty-odd climbers and they tested the programs and then we edited it again. It went to print in 2016 and I thought I would be done with it for good.

Then, the orders started coming in. Then the questions, the ideas on variations, the suggestions, and of course the 6-page email from Great Britain telling me everything wrong with what I did. I started teaching on program design multiple times each year, and urged coaches to simplify, to ask better questions, and to test before and after.

Here I sit, 4 years later with more than 100 pages of notes and ideas and clarifications. Here I sit with more than enough material for a different book entirely, but I am tied to the main idea behind Logical Progression: that programming should be progressive, yet pragmatic. Even though the methods I am going to lay out for you here vary from what I wrote 5 years ago, the principle remains the same.

In this edition, I will branch out from single-pitch-specific training programming and will include ideas on training for both less-intense efforts such as big walls, as well as training frameworks for bouldering and competition climbing.

In this edition, I will introduce the idea of building training in focused blocks, to help more advanced climbers develop specific areas of their fitness while still having the flexibility that a nonlinear program affords.

In this edition, I will discuss the value of building fitness via nonspecific modes and then “converting” it to climbing-specific fitness.

Finally, I will put forth my best effort on how a modern climber can be “battle ready” for everything from bouldering hard in the gym to cragging at Indian Creek to month-long expeditions to the greater ranges of the world without having to put month-long transitions into their programs. This was an idea that my friend Kyle Dempster kept dogging me about and one where I felt I could not give a good answer. Even though Kyle is no longer around to send me emails, his questions still remain:

“How can I excel across the entire range of this sport?”

“Why can’t I keep my endurance up in the off season?”

And my favorite: “I respect that answer, but if you were going to guess on a way it could work, what would it be?”

Much of this book will be familiar to those who have read the first edition. It is my hope that the rest of what I add enhances your understanding of those original ideas. In the end, I hope this book improves your performance.

Steve Bechtel, April 2020

INTRODUCTION

You started out climbing and you got better almost every time you went out. Occasionally you would surprise yourself by jumping two whole grades from the last time you went to the cliff. Over time, you learned that giving a climb a few efforts led to even better results, and your grades pushed higher and higher. But one weekend, you felt flat. The next, you went out and still were no better. A month on, and you started to doubt yourself and the sport. Clearly, something needed to change, and that thing was probably your preparation. You had reached the end of one level of adaptation, and now needed to up your effort to progress. You now needed to *train*.

Training works. If you have spent any time running down the road, picking weights up, or hanging from your fingertips, you know what I mean. In just a few short weeks you can see the results of your work, and you can see that a little effort goes a long way. Over time, our bodies adapt to the stress of training and the only way to make them get better again is to increase the intensity or duration of our efforts. Eventually, our stresses become so great that it might take many days to recover from a session. At the same time, we become so well-adapted to a given stress that it might take months to see a measurable improvement. At this point, organized training is the only way to get better.

Most climbers get to a point after a few years that just “working out” in the climbing gym no longer leads to improvement. Many

of us face a constant up-and-down battle between being in shape and falling out of it. Yet at the same time we see other climbers continue to push up through the grades and we can't figure out why. The "why" is *appropriate overload*. If you overload too much, you get hurt or overtrained. If you overload too little you never get stronger. Appropriate overload manifests in seeing small improvements session-to-session or week-to-week over long periods. We achieve this when we build and follow a good plan

Training only works when you can follow the plan. There are myriad good training plans out there, but I feel that most of them have one fatal flaw: inflexibility. If the program is too rigid, the natural randomness of life inevitably conflicts with it.

For years, I tried to build effective seasonal training programs based on what I had learned from coaches in other sports. I tried to build an off-season strength plan that I could somehow still integrate with occasional winter climbing days. I tried to find the right balance of effective in-season training and recovery. Sometimes, the results were brilliant, sometimes the plan sucked. Eventually, I learned about the concept of periodization - dividing training into discrete phases to focus the body's efforts on developing one primary skill at a time.

It worked. It worked until I tweaked a finger and had to take two weeks off. When it was time to come back, I didn't know where to start: Where I had stopped? Back at the beginning? Move on to the next phase? 25-odd years later, I still don't know the answer. That's why I decided to look at the question differently: instead of asking how I could make a rigid system work for climbing, I asked if there were a flexible system that would produce adequate results, even if they were slightly less than ideal.

It turns out, there is such a system. By shortening the cycle length of your training, you can effectively rest any time you need, restart any time you like, and perform at high levels within just a few weeks of effort. The system is called *nonlinear periodization*.

I believe that this system is the future of effective training for the majority of climbers due to its flexibility, effectiveness, and the fact that it helps you maintain several facets of fitness at once.

Beyond the simple concept of nonlinear programs, I think that a second layer of organization is possible, and this is the basis of why I added a second edition to a very recent book. Once the simple sequencing of a different workout focus each time you go to the gym begins to level off, you can start organizing your training into *blocks*. The blocks are simply short periods of training aimed at one physical quality, and have just enough “other stuff” in them to keep you from losing fitness in other qualities. These blocks will help lead you to what I believe will be the highest possible levels of physical readiness for climbing...then it is all up to you out on the rock.

Climbing is a skill sport, not an endurance sport and not a strength sport. Blindly pulling training habits from cycling, or running, or powerlifting will be of dubious value. We need to train only inasmuch as it helps improve our ability to move, to generate force, or to handle hard work. Beyond that, “training” should actually be practice.

Basketball players practice. Badminton players practice. Golfers practice. Yet at the very top end of each of these sports, the athletes train - and train hard. Climbing is more like these sports than it is heavy weightlifting or cycling or skiing. It is a hybrid activity that pulls from several energy systems all at once, and requires that we master an infinite number of different movements and positions. There is no season of the year that we isolate our activity to just one set of movements or to just one energy system. Even a climber who cycles between a bouldering focus and a route focus still draws from max strength, and power, and endurance throughout the year.

Many coaches, myself included, have tried to closely couple strength and conditioning with climbing. At first, the idea of exactly

replicating the demands of the sport in the gym seems the right thing to do. We erroneously think that more climbing-like activity will make us better at climbing. Moving from the climbing-as-training framework, we simply substituted the indoor climbing gym when we couldn't get to the crag. It worked pretty well.

The climbs and climbers of today are different. The 5.13 (8a) grade that was the limit in the early years of the sport is now achievable by many climbers in just a few short years of practice. The result is that the physical demands of the average climber are much greater than they were twenty years ago. Climbing with no training to help develop the supporting movements and musculature can lead to injury or plateaued progress in short order.

With all of this in mind, I suggest we rethink how we look at training. Instead of a parallel substitution for climbing when climbing is not available, we should see training as developing discrete qualities that support development "in the background." Much like the training a basketball player might do, our training should progress independently of our practice. Our training should focus on improving individual qualities of the sport, not the whole sport performance. Most of all our training should help us get better in the long-term.

"Logical Progression" refers to the simple progression we make in a well-planned program. By training different energy systems in a functional sequence, you'll see that you truly can develop all of these facets of your fitness at the same time, and perform better year-round. With this book as your guide, I hope that you'll embrace a different way of looking at training, and performing, in climbing.

